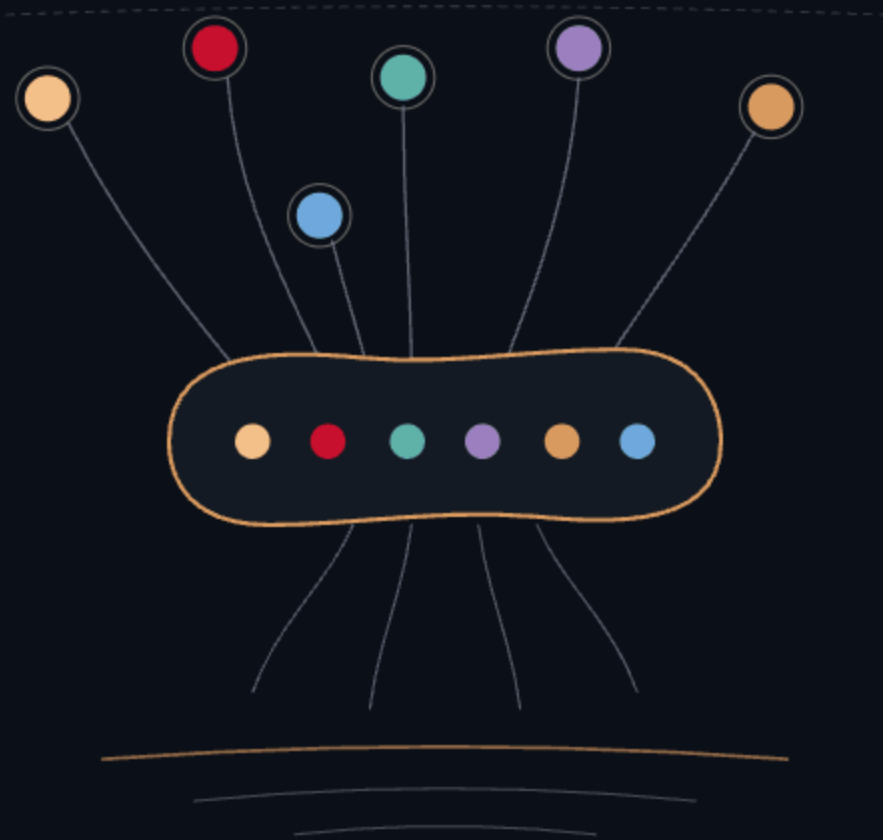


A revenue strategy for the Rogue Valley & SOU

Applied Bioregional Learning as Workforce Pell at SOU



PROPOSED BY

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We are asked for revenue ideas. One arrives in eight weeks.

A new federally-backed revenue category, Workforce Pell Grants. No tuition risk to the student. A graceful path for SOU.

Southern Oregon University is drafting a proposal and has invited the public to bring innovative revenue ideas that could supplement existing academic

tracks. On **July 20, 2026**, a new federal program takes effect that four-year universities are uniquely positioned to deliver: **Workforce Pell**.

Our Proposal: SOU adopt a Workforce Pell track under the brand Applied Bioregional Learning — short, employer-aligned, Pell-funded certificates that ladder into existing SOU degrees and anchor SOU as the regional partner for Rogue Valley employers and learners.

Effective date: U.S. Dept. of Education Final Rule Fact Sheet, May 18, 2026.

DECISION WINDOW

Spring 2026

SOU REVENUE IDEAS SOLICITED



Jul 20, 2026

WORKFORCE PELL EFFECTIVE



~8 weeks

TO ALIGN PROPOSAL & RULE

A new Pell category for short, high-quality, employment-aligned programs

PROGRAM SHAPE

- **8–15 weeks**, 150–599 clock hours
- No correspondence, noncredit, or remedial coursework
- Must be offered by an **accredited institution**
- Must award academic credit toward an existing certificate or degree

THREE ANNUAL ACCOUNTABILITY TESTS

- **70%** of participants complete within 150% of normal time
- **70%** of completers employed in the 2nd quarter after exit
- Tuition + fees $\leq$ median completer earnings – 150% of poverty line (value-added earnings; $\approx$ \$23,475 in 2026)

PROVISIONS THAT FAVOR UNIVERSITIES

- **Bachelor's-degree holders are eligible**
- **Employers may deliver up to 25%** of instruction (49% via Registered Apprenticeship)
- **Governor + state Workforce Board approve first**, then U.S. Secretary of Education

KEY TIMELINE

- **Jul 4, 2025** — OBBBA §83002 signed
- **Mar 9, 2026** — NPRM published
- **May 19, 2026** — Final rule published
- **Jul 20, 2026** — Rule effective (early opt-in Jul 1)
- **AY 2026/27 – 2028/29** — Interim phase: only 70/70 applies
- **AY 2029/30** — Transition: first value-added earnings calcs
- **AY 2030/31+** — Full accountability

Sources: OBBBA §83002 • ED Final Rule Fact Sheet, May 18, 2026 • D² Strategies (Manhattan Inst.), April 2026.

Workforce Pell was written for institutions like SOU

THE DISTINCTIVE 4-YEAR MARKET

- **Bachelor's-degree holders are eligible** — rare in Pell. Career-changers, alumni, second-degree candidates.
- **Countercyclical** to the enrollment cliff: traditional 18-year-olds decline; adult re-skilling grows with AI & industry transformation.
- **41.9M Americans** aged 25–64 have some college but no credential (SCNC).
- Four-year accreditation, stackable credit, and bachelor's-ladder pathways are **moats that for-profit short-course providers cannot cross**.

STATES RUNNING WORKFORCE PELL LIKE PROGRAMS

- **Virginia** — \$140.8M New Economy Workforce Credential Grant: 90% completion, 67% earn industry credentials, 60%+ had no prior postsecondary.
- **Tennessee** — \$1.5B coordinated short-credential-to-degree pathway model.
- **Texas** — \$605.7M performance-based community-college funding.
- **Iowa, Louisiana** — robust noncredit + wage-record data systems already exist.

Oregon's state-level data & approval infrastructure is not yet built.

SOU can be the regional model.

State precedents & SCNC figure: D² Strategies, *Workforce Pell Grants: A Strategic Opportunity for Four-Year Institutions*, Manhattan Inst., April 2026.

SOU as the Rogue Valley's hub for Applied Bioregional Learning

SOU STRENGTHS → RV DEMAND

Healthcare & allied health → CNA, LPN, Dental, Pharm Tech, CHW

Education & human services → paraprofessional, behavioral health

Sustainability & trades → HVAC, energy auditing, water systems

Business & hospitality → supervisory, lodging, food service

Outdoor & applied sciences → fire, EMS, forestry tech

A Workforce Pell track is not a pivot. It is a repackaging of existing SOU strengths into shorter, employer-aligned credentials that ladder back into degrees.

WHAT SOU ALREADY BRINGS

- Accredited four-year public university anchoring Jackson and Josephine counties.
- Existing capacity in healthcare, education, business, sustainability, outdoor sciences.
- **OHSU School of Nursing co-located at the SOU/OHSU Ashland campus** — clinical nursing pathway already in place via partnership.
- Faculty and facilities already cleared for credentialing.
- Established channels into HECC and the Rogue Workforce Partnership (WIOA, CTE).
- Alumni base already in the regional workforce — a natural first cohort.

Workforce Pell occupations across SOU's bioregional strengths

SOU STRENGTH	EXAMPLE RV OCCUPATION	10-YR OPENINGS	2025 MEDIAN WAGE
Healthcare practice	Licensed Practical / Vocational Nurse	325	\$79,414
Healthcare support	Nursing Assistant (CNA)	1,894	\$48,734
Allied health	Pharmacy Technician	355	\$54,746
Education & care economy	Preschool Teacher	483	\$38,958
Fire & emergency services	Firefighter	163	\$60,445
Forestry & environment	Forest & Conservation Tech	241	\$55,786
Sustainability & water	Water / Wastewater Treatment Op.	56	\$71,781
Skilled trades	HVAC & Refrigeration Mechanic	231	\$61,048

*Bachelor's-holder bridges (uniquely Pell-eligible under the new rule): **Registered Nurse** (1,735 openings, \$115k); **Forester** (118, \$74.5k); **Substitute Teacher** (413, \$51.7k); **Environmental Scientist** (53, \$75.9k).*

***Partner with OHSU** (nursing pathway already at the SOU/OHSU Ashland campus) for LPN/RN bridges; **partner with RCC** for CNA, dental, pharmacy tech, HVAC, welding, and other community-college-typical short-tracks.*

*Healthcare is only one band. SOU's environmental sciences, fire / wildland, and education strengths map onto Oregon's **15 in-demand sectors and 209 priority occupations** — the same list HECC will use for Workforce Pell.*

Source: OED Rogue Valley HWHD/HS Occupations 2024–2034; sector framing from 2026 Oregon Talent Assessment.

HECC and WTDB shape what counts — the program list is dynamic

WHAT THE FEDERAL RULE ACTUALLY SAYS

- Each Governor must publish a methodology for identifying **high-skill, high-wage, or in-demand** occupations (§ 690.93(b)).
- Only *one* of the three bars must clear. An occupation can qualify on **high-skill alone**.
- Lists must be **reviewed every two years** — designed to evolve.
- U.S. Dept. of Ed.: “Eligible programs will **vary across states** based on local labor market needs.”

OREGON'S FOUNDATION IS ALREADY IN PLACE

- The **2026 Oregon Talent Assessment** (ECONorthwest → HECC) is explicitly the **methodology starting point** for Workforce Pell.
- **15 in-demand sectors** including Forestry & Wood Products (LQ 3.1), Clean Energy / Climate Tech, Social Assistance / Care Economy.
- **209 priority occupations** mapped against five criteria.
- SOU's environmental, fire, and teaching strengths fit *multiple* sectors on that list.

Sources: Workforce Pell NPRM § 690.93(b); U.S. Dept. of Ed., Dec 9, 2025 briefing; 2026 Oregon Talent Assessment.

The list is not fixed. Programs SOU brings forward can be added — if HECC and WTDB are at the table.

And the Governor has directed the state to do exactly that:

“Amplify regional economic development strategies and support local efforts to utilize unique regional resources, talent pools, and market opportunities.”

— Oregon's Prosperity Roadmap, Dec 2025 (next slide)

The Governor's roadmap names this exact playbook

FROM GOAL #2: MORE LIVING WAGE JOBS, NOW

*“A **post-secondary education institution partners with local businesses and the state to create a new training or certificate program tailored to emerging industry needs. ... Employers launch a hiring process for newly created positions that specifically require the training, ensuring a **direct pipeline from education to employment.**”***

— *Oregon's Prosperity Roadmap, December 2025, p. 3*

THIS PROPOSAL HITS ALL THREE ROADMAP GOALS

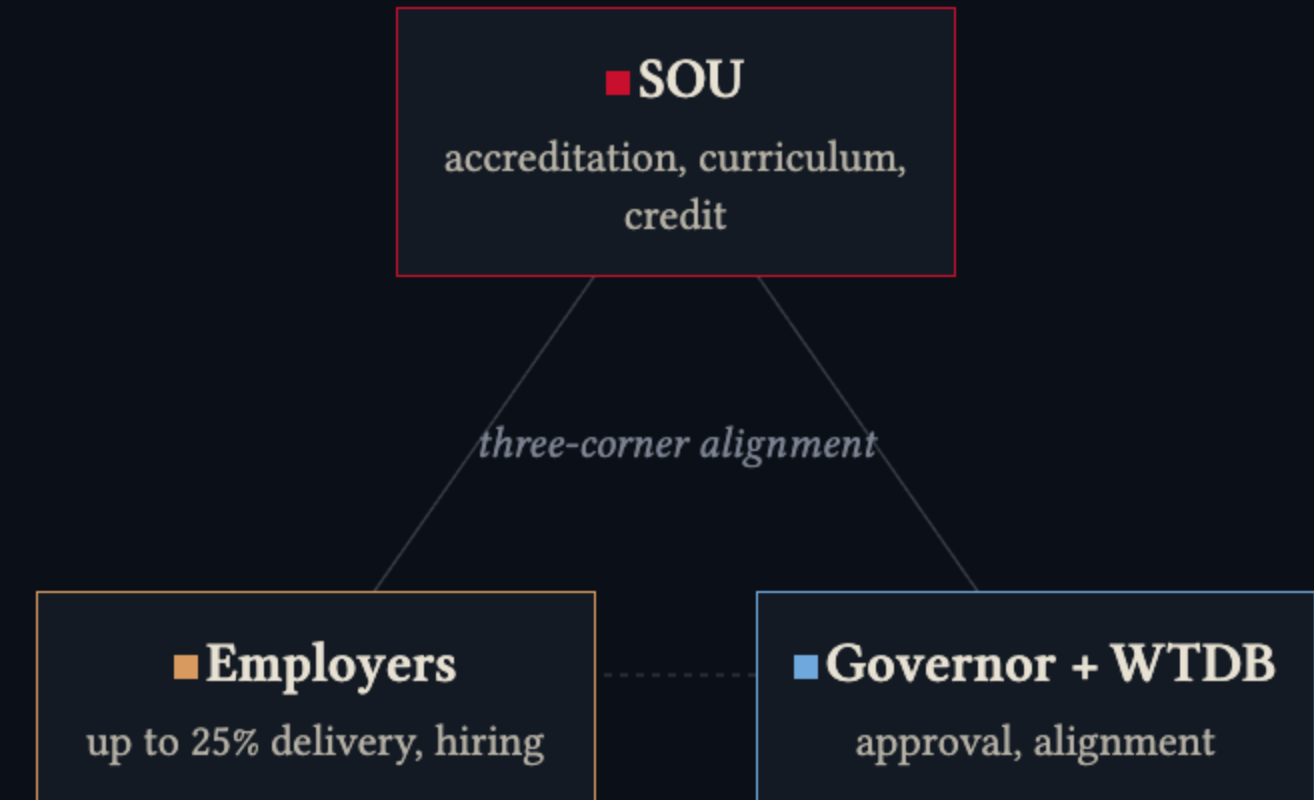
- **Goal 1 — Accelerate Economic Growth.** New GDP-contributing workforce; Pell-funded credentialing adds capacity at *no SOU capex*.
- **Goal 2 — More Living Wage Jobs, Now.** Matches the roadmap's named model: *post-secondary + employers + state*, with federal funding attached.
- **Goal 3 — Retain & Grow Oregon Businesses.** Local trained workforce reduces RV employer attrition and recruitment cost.

Source: Office of Oregon Governor Tina Kotek, *Oregon's Prosperity Roadmap*, December 2025.

Workforce Pell is, by design, a public-private partnership

The federal rule does not let an institution run a Workforce Pell program alone. Three partnerships are **statutory**:

- ■ **Government.** Governor + State Workforce Board certify alignment to high-skill, high-wage, in-demand occupations. Re-cert every two years.
- ■ **Employers.** May deliver up to 25% of instruction (49% in Registered Apprenticeship). May co-fund tuition. Hiring commitments support the 70% placement test.
- ■ **Institution.** Accreditation, curriculum, credit, outcomes tracking, advising, and academic ladder.



The data we already have suggests SOU can clear the bar

WIOA OUTCOME (2023, ALL PROGRAMS)	ROGUE VALLEY	STATEWIDE
Total WIOA participants	1,230	8,134
Measurable Skill Gain rate	60%	67%
Credential attainment (exiters)	64%	66%
Employment, 2 quarters after exit	71%	65%
Employment, 4 quarters after exit	66%	63%
Median earnings, 2 quarters after exit	\$8,500	\$9,000

Rogue Workforce Partnership already clears the 70% employment threshold for its participants. Their data-collection pipeline is the demand-side spine we'd extend with SOU's supply side.

Source: HECC WIOA Title I Workforce Data Dashboard (2023). Extract: SOURVWF/Statewide/oregon-wioa-dashboard/.

The data fusion layer: Ashland Intelligence

The 2026 Oregon Talent Assessment calls explicitly for an “Oregon Talent Dashboard.” Ashland Intelligence is the regional prototype.

THE PICTURE TODAY: FRAGMENTED DATA PICTURE

The pieces exist. The firm that fuses them is already operating in the Rogue Valley.

- ■ **Annotated Ledger** — SOU budget dashboard, *already built*. Internal financial visibility.
- ■ **RWP / WIOA reporting** — regional outcomes published quarterly through HECC. Already exists.
- ■ **HECC WIOA dashboard** — public, but covers only WIOA-funded participants; no employer demand, no per-program ROI, no sub-board geography, 2-year lag.
- ■ **Autom Insights** — the connective tissue. Architecture-first infrastructure for ingesting and fusing disparate sources; already built **SOREDI's regional economic data explorer**.

WHAT WE PROPOSE TO BUILD: ASHLAND INTELLIGENCE

Oregon's state data infrastructure isn't ready. SOU builds the regional model; the state can scale it.

- ■ **Ashland Intelligence** — the regional dashboard. Joins employer demand, institutional capacity, and federal predicates on one schema; cites every source. Will provide **API + MCP tools** for a federated query layer plus an agent-accessible interface for advising, intake, and reporting.
- ■ **White Rabbit / ROVA** — AI agent infrastructure proven to harvest structured data from disparate sources. Recruits Rogue Valley employers and runs scheduled surveys to keep the demand side current.

Statewide Scalable Model designed so EOU, OSU-Cascades, COCC, Lane CC, and other Oregon institutions can deploy the same layer.

Anatomy of a SOU Workforce Pell program

CURRICULUM

8–15 weeks.
150–599 clock
hours.
Employer-
codesigned.
Industry
assessments.
*built once,
run repeatedly.*

DELIVERY

SOU faculty + up to
25% employer-
delivered
hours (49% via RAP).
*distributed teaching,
university orchestration.*

CREDENTIAL

Stackable to existing
SOU certificate, AA,
or BA pathway.
Counts as academic
credit.
*an entry,
not a dead end.*

OUTCOMES

≥70% completion.
≥70% employed 2Q
after.
Tuition ≤ value-added
earnings cap.
*defensible to Governor
and Secretary.*

Each program approved first by the Governor (in consultation with the WTDB), then by the U.S. Secretary of Education.

Program structure: Workforce Pell Final Rule, 34 CFR Part 668 (Fed.Reg., May 19, 2026).

A new revenue line, not a rescue plan

*This isn't a turnaround. It's a **new revenue line** that grows from a modest start to a meaningful, recurring contribution over five years — and the strategic value is bigger than the dollar amount.*

The dollars compound year over year. The position compounds for decades.

01

COUNTER-CYCLICAL

Grows as 18-year-old enrollment shrinks.

Adult re-skilling expands with AI and industry transformation while the traditional pipeline contracts. The two trends pull in opposite directions; SOU gets a channel on each.

02

RECURRING & DEFENSIBLE

A federally-backed revenue category SOU doesn't have today.

Built on existing faculty and facilities. Healthy net contribution margin once mature. The category, not a one-off project.

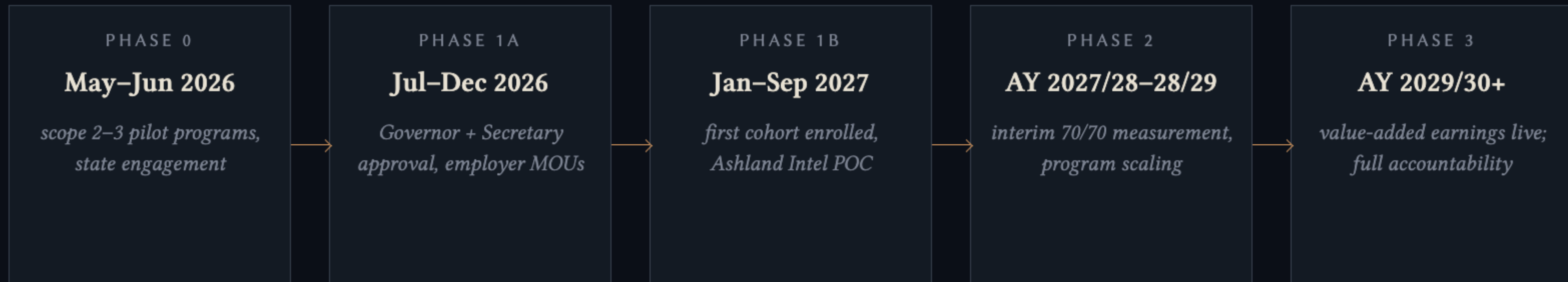
03

REGIONAL CREDIBILITY

SOU becomes the bioregional workforce hub.

A claim no other Oregon institution is yet making. Worth more, over time, than any single year's revenue line.

Four years, five phases



Federal rule gives institutions a four-year interim phase (70/70 only) before value-added earnings accountability begins. SOU can build, iterate, and scale during the buffer.

Our ask of the SOU administration

ASK 01 / 03

SOU administration

*the institution — accreditation, curriculum,
decision authority*

- Include an Applied Bioregional Learning / Workforce Pell track to the upcoming proposal as a the revenue-diversification track.
- Designate a **state-relationship lead** by **June 30, 2026**.
- Pick **2–3 pilot programs** from the Rogue Valley demand list.
- Authorize the **Annotated Ledger & ashland.ai** data work.
- Leverage direct line to **Governor Kotek** to position SOU's bioregional model as the regional fulfillment of **Prosperity Roadmap Goal #2** — the post-secondary + business + state partnership the Governor explicitly called for.

Pilot program candidates per slide 6 (RV occupations table).

Our ask of State Administration: Governor, HECC and WTDB

ASK 02 / 03

HECC + WTDB

the state — alignment criteria, Governor approval, scaling pathway

- Use the existing **Oregon CTE Skill Cluster framework** as the alignment basis for Governor approval criteria.
- Use the **Rogue Workforce Partnership 2024–2028 Local Plan** as the regional demand evidence base.
- Engage SOU as a **pilot for the regional data layer** that can scale to other Oregon institutions.
- Route engagement through the Governor's **Regional Solutions Program**; coordinate with the forthcoming **Chief Prosperity Officer** and **Prosperity Council** named in the Dec 2025 Prosperity Roadmap.
- Recognize SOU's bioregional model as the regional fulfillment of **Prosperity Roadmap Goal #2** — the post-secondary + business + state partnership the Governor explicitly called for.

Skill Cluster framework: Oregon CTE Knowledge & Skill Statements (ODE, 2024). RWP Local Plan: Rogue Workforce Partnership 2024–2028 Local Plan, signed 2024. Engagement framing: Oregon's Prosperity Roadmap (Office of Gov. Kotek, Dec 2025).

Our ask of the Rogue Valley community & its employers

ASK 03 / 03

Rogue Valley community & employers

*the region — demand, hiring, advocacy,
operating partners*

- Provide **employer intent letters** and **internship slots** for the first three programs.
- Advocate to **SOU and HECC**.
- Advocate for Oregon-based **Autom Insights** to be the **data fusion backbone** for the entire Ashland Intelligence platform.
- Contribute to the data engine that keeps the program defensible.

Time enough to start small, do it well, and let the rest of Oregon adopt the model.

THE ROGUE VALLEY FIRST — STATEWIDE IN 2028–30

Endorsed across the Rogue Valley

This proposal carries the backing of institutions whose combined authority and capacity make a Workforce Pell track at SOU not just feasible, but operable on Day One. Their endorsements are the signal that alignment is already in place.

Organization
01

Organization
02

Organization
03

Organization
04

Organization
05

Organization
06

Organization
07

Organization
08

Endorsements confirmed at each milestone of Phase 0 – partner names and logos to follow.

Sources & references

TOPIC	SOURCE
Workforce Pell statute	One Big Beautiful Bill Act §83002. Signed Jul 4, 2025.
Federal proposed rule (NPRM)	Notice of Proposed Rulemaking, U.S. Dept. of Ed., <i>Federal Register</i> (Mar 9, 2026). Comment period closed Apr 8, 2026.
Federal final rule	34 CFR Part 668 (Workforce Pell). Published <i>Federal Register</i> , May 19, 2026. Effective Jul 20, 2026; early opt-in Jul 1, 2026.
Plain-English summary	ED Fact Sheet, <i>Workforce Pell Grant Provisions of the Working Families Tax Cuts Act</i> , May 18, 2026.
Strategic analysis for 4-year institutions	T. Dunn, D ² Strategies, <i>Workforce Pell Grants: A Strategic Opportunity for Four-Year Institutions</i> , Manhattan Inst., April 2026.
Federal poverty guideline	2025 HHS Poverty Guidelines (45 CFR §1.5). Single individual: \$15,650; 150% = \$23,475.
Avg Workforce Pell grant size	Congressional Budget Office score of OBBBA §83002, 2025.
Rogue Valley occupation data	Oregon Employment Department, <i>Rogue Valley High-Wage, High-Demand, High-Skill Occupations 2024–2034</i> (xlsx). Two-county area: Jackson & Josephine.
RV WIOA participant outcomes	HECC WIOA Title I Workforce Data Dashboard (2023). Extract & tidy CSVs: SOURVWF/Statewide/oregon-wioa-dashboard/.
Rogue Workforce Partnership plan	<i>2024–2028 Local Plan</i> , Rogue Workforce Partnership, signed 2024. Plus Federal Assurances, Partners' Statement of Agreement.
Oregon Prosperity Roadmap	Office of Oregon Governor Tina Kotek, <i>Oregon's Prosperity Roadmap</i> , December 2025. Three strategic goals; Goal #2 names the post-secondary + business + state model verbatim.
Oregon talent assessment	ECONorthwest for HECC, <i>2026 Oregon Talent Assessment</i> (15 in-demand sectors; 209 priority occupations; 5 criteria). Explicitly recommends developing an Oregon Talent Dashboard.
ED program-type briefing	U.S. Dept. of Education, <i>What Types of Programs Could Be Eligible for Workforce Pell Grants?</i> , Dec 9, 2025. Confirms state authority to shape eligibility.
Oregon CTE skill clusters	Oregon Dept. of Education, CTE Knowledge & Skill Statements (16 career clusters).
SOU budget data	Annotated Ledger (internal SOU dashboard, in operation).
Architecture partner	Autom Insights, autominsights.com . Architecture-first data infrastructure; built SOREDI's regional economic data explorer.

Full source files: github.com/b3nj4m1n-46/sourvwfpg_research